

Building a Voice, Together

Foundational AAC for a student's family and team • TouchChat HD with WordPower

Facilitator script • 60 minutes • Jerry Butanda, M.S.-SLP, ATAC, AAC

Before you start

Confirm two things and fill them in live: (1) which WordPower level the student uses — 48, 60, 80, 108 with keyboard, etc. — because it changes the modeling and academics examples, and (2) whether the family has any concerns they want addressed. This dad requested the training and focuses on academics, so the academics pillar is the heart of the hour. The audience includes BCBAs; the behavior pillar is written to honor their expertise, not lecture it.

The hour at a glance

Time	Segment	Pillar	Materials
0:00	Dead device, then a silent board	Open	Device, core boards
0:07	What AAC is • TouchChat + WordPower	Foundations	Grid slide
0:14	Core, fringe, and why layout never moves	Foundations	Slides
0:20	Modeling / aided language input	Foundations	Slides
0:26	Behavior is communication (your work)	Behavior	Table, curve
0:36	AAC for academics: access, not requesting	Academics	Academics slides
0:50	What it looks like in a lesson	Academics	Slides
0:56	One team, one voice • the ask	Close	VOICE, QR

Three pillars: foundations, behavior, academics. Warm and partnership-first throughout — this family is an ally, and the team is showing up for one child.

0:00 Dead device, then a silent board

DO, THEN SAY

Hold up a powered-off device. This is his whole voice, and right now it is at two percent. What happens to his day? Take a few answers. Then the silent-board challenge: hand a few core boards to small groups, ask them to request something they actually want using only the board, no talking. Ninety seconds. Debrief: what did you do when the word wasn't there? That is his experience of every conversation.

BRIDGE

Keep this warm. The point is shared empathy, not guilt. Move into: everything today is about making sure his voice is ready and someone is always listening, at home and at school.

0:07 What AAC is, and what he uses

SAY

First, AAC is everything but speech. The device carries the most, but signs, gestures, and pointing all count, and none of it waits for the device to be perfect. Now, what he uses: TouchChat HD with WordPower. Two things to know. It is word-based, built to make sentences on the fly rather than pick single pictures. And it is

built around core vocabulary, designed by a speech-language pathologist, Nancy Inman, and current in the 2025 version of TouchChat. It is a robust, evidence-aligned system, and it grows with him as his language grows.

Show the grid slide. Note aloud that it is a generic illustration, not his exact screen, and that his real layout depends on his WordPower level. If you know the level, say it here.

0:14 Core, fringe, and the layout rule

SAY

A few hundred core words do most of the talking: want, stop, more, go, help, that, different, done. Small, reusable, everywhere, roughly eighty percent of everything any of us says all day. Fringe words are the specific ones, dinosaur, pizza, Minecraft, and they matter, but each one only fits one moment. So we model core first, because a core word works in every situation and a fringe word in only one.

And here is the rule that protects him from well-meaning adults: the buttons never move. Motor planning is why. A fluent user reaches a word the way you reach a key on a keyboard, without looking, because the location lives in the hand. Move a button and you erase that memory. The word is still on the screen and it is now lost. So changes go through the SLP, never a quick classroom fix. If a page is too much, we hide or mask cells, we do not move the survivors. Same word, same spot, every day, home and school, is how the hand learns to talk.

0:20 Modeling, the one skill

SAY

A child hears a language for about a year before their first word. We hand a device over at nine in the morning and expect sentences by lunch. Modeling gives the device the same fair start. You talk while touching the words. Three rules. Touch one or two key words as you say them, not every word. Model to show, not to quiz, no what's-this, no show-me. And retire use your words, model instead and then wait a silent ten. The pause is the teaching.

FOR THE BCBAS

Name it in your language: this is aided language input, and it is errorless. No demand, no wrong answer, no extinction burst. You are flooding the model, not testing retrieval. Everything you know about errorless teaching applies directly.

0:26 Behavior is communication

SAY

You read function fluently, so I will add just one column: what each function sounds like as words. Escape is I need out. Attention is talk to me. Tangible is I want that. Sensory is too loud. Teach the word and the behavior loses its job. That is functional communication training, and it works best when the replacement lives on his robust device and every adult in the room recognizes it. That second half is what today is really about.

THE REFRAME THAT EARNS THE ROOM

Say this plainly: I am not here to replace your expertise, I am here to point it at the device. You already do errorless teaching, that is modeling. You already fade prompts, same hierarchy on AAC. You already teach replacement behaviors, the device is the replacement. You already take data, independent versus prompted transfers directly. You are already good at this. Today aims it at his voice.

When it escalates, three moves. Stop talking, three words or fewer, because he cannot take words in. Model, do not demand. Honor the message every time, in any form. And the escape answer, because the data-

minded will think it: honoring the break request does not add escape. He already escapes by melting down. You are changing the route, not the amount. Fade the duration later. Never fade the reliability.

0:36 AAC for academics

SAY

This is the piece his dad asked for, and the field agrees it is the right ask. A device that only requests snacks and breaks is a remote control, not a voice. Academic access means he can comment, answer, question, compare, and object, about math, a story, a science lesson. The research calls this Project Core: core vocabulary taught inside real academic routines, and it is where the evidence points.

Here is the key idea. He does not need a new word for every lesson. One flexible core word does academic work in every subject. More than, one more, in math. Read more, what happens, in reading. It changed, more heat, in science. The trap is giving him a new fringe noun for each lesson, photosynthesis, denominator, so he can label but not think. Core words let him reason about any content. Presume competence: assume he has something to say about the lesson, and give him the words to say it. What he can show us is the floor of what he knows, never the ceiling.

0:50 What it looks like in a lesson

SAY

Four concrete moves. One, model during instruction, as you teach, touch the core words on his system too. Look, it changed, something different happened. Two, word of the week, pick one core word and saturate every subject with it for a week. Three, describe instead of label-hunt, teach him to say it's big and fast with core words rather than hunting for the exact noun, because describing generalizes and labeling does not. Four, ask real questions and then wait, what do you think, what happens next, then a silent ten, so he has room to have an idea.

And the long game is literacy. WordPower has a keyboard. As his reading and spelling grow, the keyboard opens every word in the language, nothing off-limits because it is not a button. Model letters the way you model core, pair speech with symbols and text, and keep alphabet access available even for emerging spellers. That is the ceiling we are building toward.

0:56 One team, one voice

SAY

Here is what we each carry. Everyone models on the device, every day, every setting. The team keeps the layout and the expectations the same, home and school, and changes go through the SLP. In academics, core words in every lesson, real questions, and the assumption that he has something to say. And the device gets a VOICE check daily, visible, on, in reach, charged, every setting, because it is his voice and it has to be ready. He is already communicating. Our job is to make sure someone is always ready to listen.

CLOSE

End on partnership. Thank the family for bringing you in and the team for showing up for one child. Point to the QR: the full resource page has the foundations guide, the modeling and core cheat sheets, the academics playbook, and a family one-pager. Leave the QR up as people go.

Questions you should expect

Won't giving him the device make him stop trying to talk?

The research runs the other way: AAC supports speech development, it does not suppress it. Modeling language on the device, paired with your own speech, tends to increase vocalizations and words over time. There are no prerequisites to deserve a voice.

(From a BCBA) Isn't honoring the break request just reinforcing escape behavior?

He already gets escape — by melting down, every time. Honoring the break button doesn't add escape; it changes which route delivers it, from a dangerous one to a communicative one. You then fade duration and build tolerance on your usual schedule. You never fade the reliability of the request. This is FCT, and it's squarely in your wheelhouse.

(From the parent) How do I do this at home without being his therapist?

You don't run therapy — you narrate life. Touch a few core words while you talk during dinner, in the car, at bedtime. “More?” “All done.” “Let's go.” Ten seconds of modeling woven through the day beats a formal session. The home one-pager gives you the starting words.

He mostly just explores the buttons — is that misuse?

That's babbling, and it's how every human learns a new language. Exploration is developmental, not misuse. Keep modeling; the meaningful use grows out of the exploration.

What if a lesson word isn't on his device?

Two answers. Most academic thinking runs on core words he already has, so describe and reason with those first. For a genuinely needed fringe word, note it and bring it to the SLP to add in the right place — nobody adds or moves buttons mid-lesson.

Materials checklist

Slides or the deck. A powered-off device and a few printed core boards for the cold open. The student's device or a demo iPad with his WordPower level if available, for the modeling moment. The family one-pager and the team foundations guide as leave-behinds. The resource-page QR, printed large. Confirm the WordPower level before you start.

Evidence base

Project Core (Center for Literacy and Disability Studies, UNC): core vocabulary instruction within academic routines for students with significant disabilities.

O'Neill, Light & McNaughton (2018). Aided AAC input and communication outcomes: meta-analysis, JSLHR, 61, 1743-1765.

Erickson & Koppenhaver: comprehensive literacy for students with significant disabilities; alphabet access and emergent literacy.

WordPower (N. Inman) within TouchChat HD, PRC-Salttillo, current version 2025. Word-based, core-centered vocabulary.

The grid and academic diagrams in the deck are original illustrations of AAC concepts, not reproductions of the TouchChat or WordPower software.